that game turned out. Romania were a good, technical side, even without Gheorghe Hagi who was suspended, but they weren't that good. We should never have got ourselves into a position where they could put us out. After going a goal down, we got ourselves 2–1 up and should have gone on to win the game from there. After they equalized, it felt like we didn't have the belief in ourselves to get back at them. We were hanging on for the draw. All it took then was one misjudgement, right at the end, to put Romania into the quarter-finals instead of us.

I was standing near the halfway line when Phil Neville slid in on their player and the penalty was given. It was a strange moment. Unreal: it felt like it shouldn't have been happening, like it was part of another game, not the one we'd been playing for the last ninety minutes. I felt so bad for Phil. He'd had a good game that afternoon and a good tournament. When the final whistle went, I found myself thinking about him straight away. *I know what's going to happen, what's going to be said about you now.*

I went over and put an arm round him. There's nothing I could have said or done, though, to stop him getting shouldered with the blame for us losing to Romania and going out of the competition. The abuse he got wasn't as fierce as I'd had after France 98 but it was enough. More than enough. No wonder England players sometimes go into big games wondering if they're going to make the big mistake and get ripped apart for it afterwards. Like I've said, for the England team to really move on, we need to get over that way of thinking.

That afternoon in Charleroi, around the ground and back in the dressing rooms afterwards, there was this sense of disbelief. After the high of beating Germany on the same ground just a few days before, to follow it with the result against Romania was devastating. The win the previous Saturday had lifted everybody's expectations—the fans', the media's and the players' themselves—and, in a split second, all that had gone. It was hard to take. You can't help but dream along with the England supporters, even if the manager and team-mates like Gary Neville try to bring you back down to earth. We felt crushed, like the fans, to be going back home so soon.

The minutes in the dressing room afterwards and then the first days in England are a blur to me now. I remember thinking back, during that time, to 1999 and how the Bayern Munich players must have felt after United won the European Cup. It's not like the opposition have taken the lead and are beating you two-or three-nothing, controlling the game. One minute everything's there in front of you, the next it's snatched away. It happens so quickly and